

# Communication & Language

44 words · Communication & Language

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## NOUNS

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### accent

the distinctive way a person pronounces words, typical of their region, country, or social background

*She still has a slight French accent, even after twenty years in London.*

### interpreter

a person who translates speech aloud so that people who don't share a language can communicate

*The hospital arranged an interpreter for her appointment.*

### jargon

specialised vocabulary used within a particular profession or group, often unclear to outsiders

*The report was so full of technical jargon that nobody outside the IT department understood it.*

### intonation

the rise and fall of the pitch of the voice while speaking

*Her rising intonation at the end of the sentence made it sound like a question.*

### loanword

a term taken from another language and used with little or no change

*'Déjà vu' is a loanword the English language borrowed straight from French.*

### expletive

a swear word, especially one used to express anger, pain, or surprise

*He let out a stream of expletives when he stubbed his toe on the doorframe.*

## ADJECTIVES

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### fluent

able to speak or write a language easily, accurately, and without hesitation

*After a year working in Tokyo, he became fluent in Japanese.*

### emoji

a small digital image or icon used to express an idea, object, or feeling in a message

*She replied to his apology with nothing but a shrugging emoji.*

### slang

very informal words and expressions, typically used in speech among particular groups

*Half the slang my students use, I have to look up myself.*

### dialect

a regional or social variety of a language with its own vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation

*Geordie is a dialect from the north-east of England that some outsiders find hard to follow.*

### neologism

a word or expression newly coined and not yet in general use

*'Photobomb' was a neologism a decade ago; now it's a household word.*

### vernacular

the everyday language spoken by ordinary people in a particular place, as opposed to formal or literary language

*The play is written entirely in the local vernacular, which makes it tricky for non-natives to follow.*

### diplomatic

skilled at dealing with people or difficult situations without causing offence

*Try to be diplomatic when you explain why the project is running late.*

**blunt**

very direct in speech, without trying to soften the message

*He's painfully blunt sometimes, but at least you always know where you stand.*

**moribund**

in terminal decline and likely to disappear completely, especially of a language, custom, or institution

*The dialect is now moribund, spoken fluently by only a handful of elderly residents.*

**tactful**

careful not to say or do anything that might embarrass or upset someone

*She was tactful enough not to mention his mistake in front of the whole team.*

**straight-talking**

honest and direct in speech, without avoiding difficult or awkward truths

*She's known as a straight-talking manager who always tells you exactly where you stand.*

**VERBS**

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**pronounce**

to say a word or sound in a particular way

*It took me weeks to learn how to pronounce his name correctly.*

**translate**

to express the meaning of words or text in a different language

*Could you translate this sign for me? I can't read a word of it.*

**enunciate**

to pronounce words clearly and distinctly

*The radio presenter was trained to enunciate every syllable clearly.*

**mispronounce**

to pronounce a word incorrectly

*Tourists often mispronounce the name of the town.*

**rephrase**

to say or write something again using different words

*Could you rephrase the question? I'm not sure what you're asking.*

**sugarcoat**

to make something unpleasant or difficult sound more acceptable than it really is

*Don't sugarcoat it, just tell me if the presentation was bad.*

**PHRASAL VERBS**

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**look up**

to search for a piece of information, for example in a dictionary or online

*I looked the word up on my phone the moment he said it.*

**die out**

to gradually disappear or stop existing

*Without younger speakers, the language will die out within a generation.*

**tone down**

to make something less extreme, forceful, or offensive

*The editor asked her to tone down some of the language in the article.*

**catch on**

to become popular or widely used

*The abbreviation caught on so quickly that most people forgot where it came from.*

**COLLOCATIONS**

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**mother tongue**

the first language a person learns as a child

*Dutch is her mother tongue, though she now speaks English at work every day.*

**body language**

communication through gestures, posture, and facial expression rather than words

*His body language gave him away: arms crossed, eyes down, clearly uncomfortable.*

### small talk

polite, light conversation about unimportant things, especially with people you don't know well  
*I'm useless at small talk. I never know what to say at networking events.*

### text speak

the abbreviated, informal style of writing typical of messaging and online chat  
*His replies are pure text speak ('u', 'gr8', 'idk') and I can barely read them.*

### false friend

a word in a foreign language that looks similar to one in your own but has a different meaning  
*'Embarrassed' and 'embarazada' are false friends between English and Spanish: one means embarrassed, the other means pregnant.*

### place an accent

to work out where a person's accent is from  
*I couldn't place his accent at all. Somewhere in the Baltics, maybe?*

## IDIOMS

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### on the tip of my tongue

describes a word or name you almost remember but can't quite recall  
*Her name's on the tip of my tongue. Give me a second, it'll come to me.*

### beat around the bush

avoid saying what you really mean by talking about other things first  
*Just tell me what happened, don't beat around the bush.*

### lose the thread

to stop being able to follow what someone is saying  
*He went off on so many tangents that I completely lost the thread.*

### coin a phrase

to invent a new word or expression  
*Nobody knows for certain who first coined the phrase 'couch potato'.*

### lost in translation

describes meaning, humour, or nuance that disappears when something moves from one language to another  
*A lot of the joke's charm gets lost in translation.*

### get to the point

to start talking about the main thing you want to say, instead of talking around it  
*Could you get to the point? We're running out of time.*

### get your ear in

to become accustomed to understanding an unfamiliar accent  
*Rough, honestly, but I think I'm finally starting to get my ear in.*

## SET PHRASES

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### get your point across

to succeed in making people understand what you mean  
*He barely speaks any Italian, but somehow he always gets his point across.*

### watch your language

used to tell someone to stop swearing or speaking rudely  
*Watch your language, please; there are children in the room.*

## MODERN SLANG

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### waffle

to talk or write a lot without giving any useful information  
*He waffled for ten minutes without actually answering my question.*

### lingo

language, especially the specialised or unfamiliar vocabulary used by a particular group  
*I couldn't follow a word of the lawyers' lingo.*